

COMBAT SPORTS



FIGHTING SPORTS, which had their origins in ancient Greece, developed in different ways. Judo and the other martial arts, such as karate, kung-fu, taekwondo, and aikido, evolved in the East, often as a way of life or connected with religion. Only since the 1950s have their secrets become known in the West and their popularity as sports spread. The chief Western combat sports are boxing, wrestling, and fencing. These have Eastern counterparts – kick boxing, sumo, and kendo respectively.

Judo

Judo means “the gentle way”, and players try to use their opponent’s weight and strength against them. Players can use more than 40 recognized throws to put their opponent on their back. Or, in groundwork, they try to pin their opponent’s back on the mat with a hold. In competition, a referee awards points for throws and holds.



The arm is used to absorb the impact of a throw.

Scoring

A perfect throw or 30-second hold-down earns *ippon*, worth ten points, and wins the contest outright. Near-perfect throws or shorter hold-downs earn *waza-ari*, worth seven points, and two of these win a contest. If the contest goes its full length, other scores and penalties count.

The shoulder is pinned to the ground during groundwork.



Performing a hip throw



The judo suit, or “judogi”, is a loose-fitting cotton jacket and trousers.

Players grip an opponent by the jacket.

- Red
- Black
- Brown
- Blue
- Green
- Orange
- Yellow

Belts

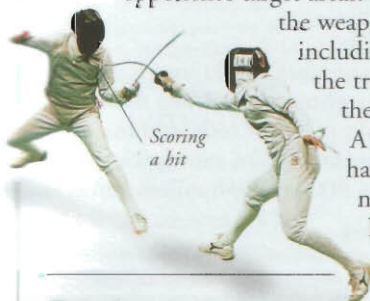
The colour of the belt a player wears around the jacket indicates his or her grade. Judo grades range from *kyu*, meaning student, to the advanced *dan* grades when the player wears a black belt, or red for ninth or tenth *dan*.

Fencing

In fencing, points are scored by registering “hits” on the opponent’s target areas. These vary according to the weapon used: the upper body including the arms for a sabre; the trunk only for a foil; and the whole body for an épée. A bout lasts until one player has scored the agreed number of hits or the time limit has been reached.

Weapons

A foil and sabre must not weigh more than 500 g (17.5 oz), an épée not more than 770 g (26.9 oz). The foil and épée have a 90-cm (35.4-in) blade and must strike the target with the point. The edges of a sabre’s 88-cm (34.7-in) blade may be used for a hit.



Scoring a hit



Wired-up over-jacket

Fencing kit

Fencers wear protective clothing on the body, a mask of steel or plastic mesh, and a padded gauntlet on the sword hand. In competition, target areas may be electrically wired to register hits, signalled by lights.

Boxing

Boxers fight in a raised, square “ring” bounded by ropes. Amateur boxing is staged over three three-minute rounds. Professional fights last up to 12 rounds (15 in title fights). Fights may be won by a knock-out, by the referee stopping the fight, or on points.

Muhammad Ali

Arguably the most colourful figure in sport, Muhammad Ali (b.1942) was the first boxer to regain the world heavyweight title three times. Born Cassius Clay, he won the Olympic light-heavyweight title in 1960, turned professional, then gained the world heavyweight crown with a shock win over Sonny Liston in 1964. He changed his name when he joined the Black Muslims.



Amateur’s headgear

Padded gloves

High-sided boots

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GREECE, ANCIENT

Other combat sports

Like judo, most of the other Eastern combat sports come from Japan, including karate, sumo wrestling, and kendo.



Karate, meaning “empty hands”, uses kicks and strikes by the hands, elbows, and head.



Sumo wrestling is steeped in the ritual of the Shinto religion. Each contestant tries to throw his opponent or push him out of the ring.



Kendo pays tribute to the samurai fighters of feudal times. “Swords” are bamboo sticks.

JAPAN, HISTORY OF

OLYMPIC GAMES

RELIGIONS

WEAPONS